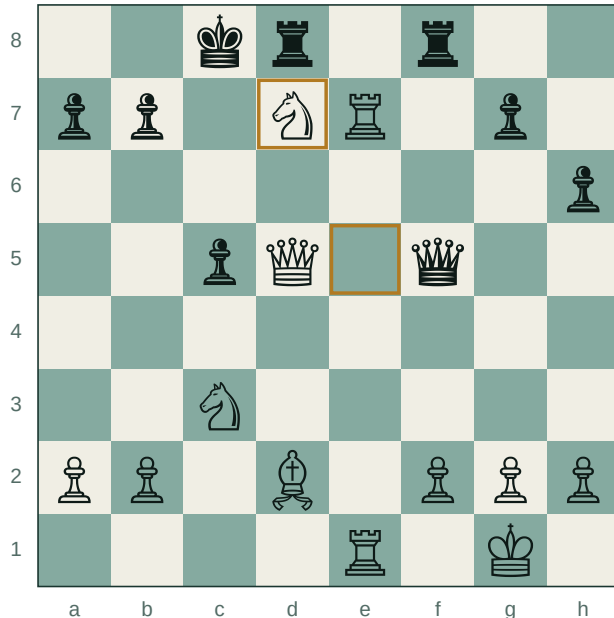


# Back-rank mates: Black, move 19

Back-rank mates

Black to move



Previous move: 19.Nxd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**19...Qxf2+ 20. Kh1 Qf1+ 21. Rxf1 Rxf1#**

**19...Qxf2+** Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f2 it attacks king on g1, rook on e1 and bishop on d2. Recorded reply: **20.Kh1**.

**20...Qf1+** Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f1 it attacks king on h1 and rook on e1. Recorded reply: **21.Rxf1**.

**21...Rxf1#** Mate: rook on f1 gives check; White has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h1. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

**CHECKPOINT**

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f1. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

A flight square, an interposition, or a countercheck may refute an apparent mate. Check all three before sacrificing material.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

A king trapped behind its own pawns may have no flight square when a rook or queen reaches its back rank. The entry square and its defenders are critical.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Inspect the king's pawn shelter, then find how a heavy piece can enter the last rank or remove its defender.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.